

Post-Release Steps — Visibility and Adoption

Status: Working plan. Check items off in place. **Date:** 2026-07-30 **Owner:** Ed Barlow **Goal:** Move Drydock from "published" to "used by people who are not me."

0. Diagnosis

Several posts to r/SpecDrivenDevelopment produced few hard hits. Three causes, in order of impact:

1. **Channel.** A small subreddit is a low-traffic venue, and repeated self-posts into one small venue is the lowest-yield distribution pattern available. The audience there already believes in specification-driven development; the people with the pain do not know the category name.
2. **Pitch.** "The missing process layer for specification-driven development" is a category claim. A reader needs a pain claim: their agent forgets, contradicts itself, and cannot prove what it built.
3. **Activation cliff.** The old README asked for four configuration commands and nine subcommands before anything happened, plus eight pieces of new vocabulary. Evaluation stops long before value appears.

Governing rule: fix the front door before spending another post. Traffic to a page that does not convert is wasted twice — the post and the audience.

1. Phase 1 — Front Door

Nothing else in this plan may start until this phase is complete.

- ☒ Benefit-first tagline replacing the category claim.
- ☒ Whole-command-surface graphic ([docs/drydock_process.svg](#) / [.png](#)) at the top of the README.
- ☒ Collapse the duplicated quickstart; hero install is two lines.
- ☒ Link the Product Comparison Matrix from [Why It Is Different](#).
- ☐ Put the process graphic on webcloudstudio.com in place of the autoplay video. Video below the fold, as a secondary option, never as the primary explanation.
- ☐ Record a 60–90 second asciinema or terminal GIF of one real run. Place it directly under the process graphic in the README. No music, no titles, no editing beyond trimming dead time.
- ☐ Read the README top-to-bottom as a stranger. Delete every sentence that does not earn its place before the reader has decided to try it.
- ☐ Move the vocabulary (Blueprint, QuarterDeck, Rigging, Soundings, Sea Trials, Commander) below the first call to action. The metaphor is an asset after commitment and a tax before it.
- ☐ Verify a clean install on a machine with no Drydock configuration: `uv tool install drydock-sdd && drydock init MyApp`. Every prompt, error, and missing prerequisite the new user hits gets fixed or documented. This is the highest-value engineering work in the plan.

Exit criterion: a stranger can state what Drydock does for them after ten seconds on the README.

2. Phase 2 — Proof Assets

Drydock's structural advantage over every competitor is that it produces receipts. Nobody in this space shows them. Show them.

- ☐ Choose the reference project. Small, real, comprehensible in one sitting, not a to-do app. The CommonMark work (c3.sh) or a scoped slice of Marina are candidates.
- ☐ Build it end to end with Drydock. Do not hand-correct; if it fails, fix Drydock.
- ☐ Publish as a public repository, drydock-example-`<name>`, containing the generated application **and** the Blueprint, MANIFEST.md, SOUNDINGS.md, SCORECARD.md, and the run logs.
- ☐ Write the README of that repo as a guided tour: here is the specification, here is the graph, here is the step that built this file, here is the evidence it was verified.
- ☐ Link it from the Drydock README hero. This is the single strongest asset in the plan.
- ☐ Optional and high-value: the **rework experiment**. Build the same small application three ways — unstructured agent prompting, Spec Kit, Drydock. Measure something honest: rework rate, steps to green tests, time to first correct build. Publish the numbers even where Drydock loses. Credibility from an unfavorable number exceeds any favorable claim.

3. Phase 3 — Content That Is Not An Announcement

"Check out my tool" is ignored. Artifacts are not. Each item below is a standalone piece of value that mentions Drydock as a footnote.

- ☐ **Publish the comparison matrix publicly.** docs/Product_Comparison_Matrix.md is currently inert. Drydock vs. GitHub Spec Kit vs. Kiro vs. BMAD vs. a plain CLAUDE.md, explicit about where each one wins. Highest-traffic content type in this niche, ranks in search, gets linked by others, and does not read as promotion when it is honest.
- ☐ **"Roast my specification format."** Post the Typed Specification and ask for destruction. Asking for critique outperforms asking for adoption by roughly an order of magnitude, and the people who show up to criticize are the first real users.
- ☐ **"Why I made my agent write acceptance criteria before code."** Teachable post, tool as a footnote.
- ☐ **Convert the video assets to text.** The 10-minute overview and the tutorial become written posts with embedded stills. Text indexes in search; video does not, and nobody on Reddit or HN clicks a video from a stranger.
- ☐ **Cut 30–60 second vertical clips** from the existing videos for LinkedIn and X.
- ☐ **Syndicate** each written post: webcloudstudio.com canonical, then dev.to and Hashnode with canonical tags pointing home.

4. Phase 4 — Channels

Ordered by expected yield. Do not open a channel before Phase 1 is complete.

Channel	Post type	Notes
Hacker News (Show HN)	Launch	One shot. Draft prepared in ideas/SHOW_HN_POST.md. Tue–Thu, 08:00–10:00 ET. Block the whole day.

Channel	Post type	Notes
r/ClaudeAI, r/ChatGPTCoding	Problem post	Far larger than r/SpecDrivenDevelopment and directly on the pain. Lead with the problem.
r/ExperiencedDevs	Teachable post	Hostile to promotion, receptive to hard-won process. Never link-drop.
LinkedIn	Case study, clips	Underused given your profile. Engineering leadership is the buyer persona and your credentials carry there.
Lobste.rs	Launch	Requires an invite. Worth acquiring.
r/programming, r/LocalLLaMA	Comparison, experiment	Data-driven posts only; announcements die.
Discords/forums for agent tooling	Participation	Contribute value for weeks before ever mentioning Drydock.
r/SpecDrivenDevelopment	Continued presence	Keep it, but it is a secondary venue, not the strategy.

Rules for all channels:

- ☐ Never post the same text to two venues. Rewrite for each audience.
- ☐ Never respond to criticism with defense. Concede, ask a question, thank them.
- ☐ Never link-drop into a competitor's issue tracker or community. Answer the question that was asked; mention Drydock only if it is directly responsive.

5. Phase 5 — Cadence

One artifact per week for six weeks, each pointing back to the worked example. Sustained presence beats any single launch.

- ☐ Week 1 — Comparison matrix published.
- ☐ Week 2 — Worked-example repository announced.
- ☐ Week 3 — "Roast my specification format."
- ☐ Week 4 — Show HN.
- ☐ Week 5 — Tutorial written up as text.
- ☐ Week 6 — Rework-rate experiment with numbers.
- ☐ Week 7 — Review the measurements below and decide whether to continue, change the pitch, or stop.

6. Measurement

Stars are vanity. Track these instead, weekly, in one place.

Metric	Source	Meaning
PyPI downloads	<code>pydiststats recent</code> <code>drydock-sdd</code>	Did anyone install it
Unique repo clones	GitHub Insights → Traffic	Did anyone look at the source
README referrers	GitHub Insights → Referring sites	Which channel actually works
Issues and discussions opened by strangers	GitHub	The only metric that matters. A stranger filing an issue used the tool.
Second-run rate	Manual, from issue and discussion content	Did anyone run <code>drydock build</code> twice

- ☐ Set up the weekly measurement note. One file, one table, appended weekly.
- ☐ Decide on opt-in anonymous telemetry: implement, or explicitly decide against it and stop reconsidering.

7. Not Doing

Recorded so these do not get relitigated:

- Paid advertising. The audience is too small and too ad-blind for it to pay back.
- Renaming the nautical vocabulary. It is a genuine identity asset; the fix is sequencing, not removal.
- Chasing star counts.
- A Discord or community server before there are users. An empty server is negative signal.
- Changing the subscription-CLI-only stance to court a wider audience. It is a real differentiator and the economics behind it are sound.

8. The Uncomfortable Step

Cheaper and more informative than the next ten posts:

- ☐ Get **five senior engineers** to run the quickstart while you watch — screen share, silent, no help offered. Write down the exact second each one gets confused and the exact thing they were looking at.

If the confusion is consistently in the same place, that is the whole marketing problem and no amount of distribution will route around it.